

Skin in Every Colour

The Fitzpatrick spectrum, melanin, and the textured, darker skin every curriculum before this one forgot

Learning Objectives

- Classify skin using the Fitzpatrick scale, and explain its uses and its limits
- Identify skin type (oily, dry, combination, normal) independently of skin tone
- Recognise how common conditions present differently on deeper skin tones
- Explain why Amber refuses to treat any skin tone as the invisible exception

A gap the old curricula left open

For decades, the global beauty education industry was written, largely, for one kind of skin — and every other kind was squeezed into the final page of a chapter, as an "also." A practitioner trained this way can describe a rash on pale skin with total confidence and go blank in front of the exact same rash on deep brown skin, because she was never taught to see it there. Amber Atelier was built, in part, to close this exact gap.

A practitioner who can only read one skin tone has not learned skin. She has learned a fraction of it, and called it the whole.

The Fitzpatrick scale — a useful tool, honestly taught

Developed in 1975 by dermatologist Thomas Fitzpatrick, the Fitzpatrick scale classifies skin into six types, by how it responds to UV exposure:

- **Type I** — very fair, always burns, never tans
- **Type II** — fair, burns easily, tans minimally
- **Type III** — medium, sometimes burns, tans gradually

- **Type IV** — olive, burns minimally, tans well — where much Indian skin sits
- **Type V** — brown, rarely burns, tans deeply — where much Indian skin also sits
- **Type VI** — deeply pigmented, almost never burns

Teach it, and teach its limits honestly. The scale was built around sun response, not skin health, and says nothing about oiliness, sensitivity, or condition. Never let "type" and "worth" collapse into the same word.

◆ Figure 2.1 · The Fitzpatrick Spectrum



The six Fitzpatrick types, Type I through Type VI, by UV/sun response.

Type is not tone — the second axis

Skin *tone* and skin *type* are entirely separate measurements. Type describes how the skin behaves day to day, regardless of colour:

- **Oily** — overactive sebaceous glands, shine, enlarged pores, congestion
- **Dry** — underactive oil production, tightness, flaking, compromised barrier
- **Combination** — oily T-zone, drier cheeks; the most common type worldwide
- **Normal** — balanced oil and moisture, the least common in reality

Every skin tone contains every skin type. Never assume one from the other.

How conditions present differently

- **Redness and inflammation.** On fair skin, inflammation reads pink or red. On deeper skin, it more often reads as darkening, a dusky or violet undertone, or a change in texture.

- **Post-inflammatory hyperpigmentation (PIH).** Deeper skin tones are significantly more prone to PIH — the dark marks that linger after a spot heals — because more active melanocytes mean a stronger pigment response to injury.
- **Scarring and keloid risk.** Deeper skin tones carry a higher risk of keloid scarring, changing how you approach extraction and exfoliation.
- **Dryness and ashiness.** On deeper skin, dryness often reads first as a visible grey or ashen cast rather than obvious flaking.



The Origin BubbleWest Africa · Ghana · Shea butter

The Tree That Does Not Bear Fruit for the Impatient

In the savannah belt of northern Ghana, the shea tree grows wild — untamed by orchard rows, uninterested in schedules. It takes fifteen years before it bears its first fruit, and forty-five before it reaches its full yield. No one who plants a shea tree expects to harvest it themselves.

The harvest belongs almost entirely to women. They gather the fallen fruit at dawn, boil the kernels, then crush and knead them by hand for hours — a labour passed from mother to daughter for longer than written memory holds.

Long before any laboratory confirmed it, these women knew what the butter did: eased the crack of dry harmattan winds, soothed burns and irritation, kept mothers and infants supple through the driest season.

The science

Shea butter is exceptionally rich in *oleic and stearic fatty acids*, giving it a deeply emollient, barrier-repairing effect, and contains natural *triterpenes* with anti-inflammatory properties.

Why this belongs here: Shea butter remains one of the world's most trusted allies for dry and deeper skin tones prone to visible ashiness.

The Amber standard on tone

Hold this for the rest of your career: **Amber treats conditions, never complexions.** You will learn every presentation, on every tone, with equal seriousness — because a client who cannot be read correctly cannot be treated correctly.

Key Terms

0

[object Object]

1

[object Object]

2

[object Object]

3

[object Object]

Practical Activity · The Full Spectrum

Find three reputable clinical images of the same condition shown on light, medium, and deep skin tones. Write a short comparison noting how the presentation changes across tones. **This exercise trains the eye you will rely on for the rest of your career.**